

would probably be sitting on orange crates. She helps to balance my extremes, and I balance hers.

These distinctive personality types should not be ignored when a couple works out the decision-making function in their marriage. We Christians have tended to stereotype the roles of husband and wife, but when we do that, we ignore the totality of God's Word on the subject and fail to recognize psychological realities.

The Scriptures do not draw an exact parallel between home relationships and the church. Instead, when the totality of God's Word is considered, and not just isolated passages, it is evident that mutual decision-making is a more accurate description of the Bible's counsel on the matter. Genesis 2:18 indicates that the woman should be a suitable helper for her husband. In 1 Peter 3:7 the husband is warned to treat his wife with consideration and respect, "so that nothing will hinder" his prayers. When a husband avoids or ignores his wife's counsel on any matter, including finances, he should expect his prayers to be hindered. The same can be said for a wife who does not give her husband the respect that God has assigned him as the head of his family.

Thus the stereotype does not work when it tends to diminish the balance God builds into a marriage. If the husband is the dominant personality and the primary decision maker, there is still the danger that he will tend to exclude his wife from financial decisions, investments, and major purchases.

But the stereotype completely breaks down when the husband is not naturally a dominant person. Sometimes he is, but in a high percentage of the families I have counseled, the wife is the dominant personality and the decision maker. Does that mean that God made an error in giving her a dominant personality and her husband a subdued personality? No, but it does mean that the wife in such a marriage must learn to listen to the counsel of her husband, just as dominant husbands must listen to their less dominant wives. If the wife hasn't learned to do this, she will be seen as pushy and domineering, rather than respectful. God created husband and wife to function as a single working unit, each with